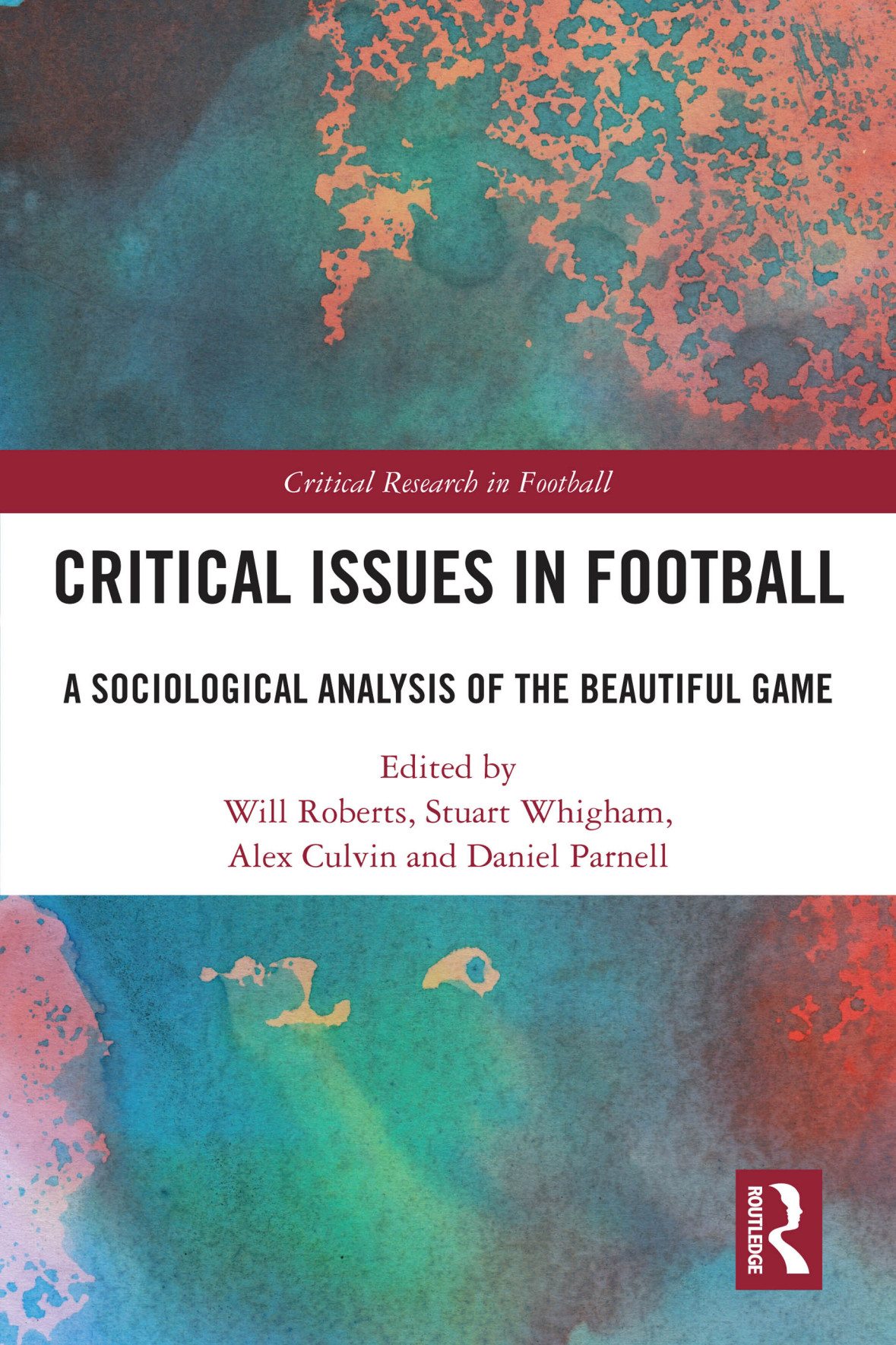




Critical Research in Football

CRITICAL ISSUES IN FOOTBALL

A SOCIOLOGICAL ANALYSIS OF THE BEAUTIFUL GAME

Edited by
Will Roberts, Stuart Whigham,
Alex Culvin and Daniel Parnell



Critical Issues in Football

Showcasing some of the most important current research in football studies, this book demonstrates the value of social theory and sociology in helping us to better understand the world's favourite sport.

This book sheds critical new light on key issues in contemporary football, with each chapter using a different theoretical lens, drawing on the work of key thinkers from Elias and Foucault to Hall and Maffesoli. It explores issues and topics central to the study of modern football, including homophobia, feminist-informed coaching practice, the racialised experiences of black professional footballers, the concussion crisis and the role of identity in online football communities. It also looks ahead at the issues that are likely to define the research agenda in football studies in years to come.

This is fascinating reading for any student or researcher with an interest in football, the sociology of sport, social theory or social issues in wider society.

Will Roberts is Senior Lecturer in Sport Development and Coaching in Te Huataki Waiora School of Health at the University of Waikato, New Zealand. Will's research interests cohere around pedagogical and socio-cultural aspects of sport, with a focus on the instrumentalism of coaching and youth sport. He is Series Editor for the *Routledge Studies in Constraints-Based Methodologies in Sport* series and continues to work in football in a coaching and consulting role, supporting coaches, professional clubs and national organisations regarding their focus on holistic development of young people in sport. Will tweets from @w_roberts6

Stuart Whigham is Senior Lecturer in Sport, Coaching and Physical Education in the Department of Sport, Health Sciences and Social Work at Oxford Brookes University, UK. His research interests in the sociology and politics of sport focus on national identity, nationalism and sport; the politics of sport and sporting events; the politics of the Commonwealth Games and the sociology and politics of Scottish sport. He has recently acted as Guest Editor for the *Sport in Society* journal for the 'Sport and Nationalism: Theoretical Perspectives' Special Issue. Stuart tweets from @StuartWhigham

Alex Culvin works in player relations at FIFPRO and is Senior Lecturer at Leeds Beckett University, UK. Alex's research interests lie in elite sport, business management, policy, work and gender. She has recently co-edited two books on professional women's sport and professional women's football respectively. Alex currently acts as Chair of the Football Collective, a global network of football scholars, as the knowledge and research exchange lead. Alex completed her PhD in 2019, in the first study to examine professional football as work for women in England. As a former Professional Footballer, Alex had unique access to professional footballers and maintains considerable networks within professional sport. Alex tweets from @alexculvin

Daniel Parnell is Associate Professor in Sport Business at the University of Liverpool Management School, UK. Dan's research interests lie in business management, policy, and social and economic networks in sport. He serves as Co-Editor-in-Chief of the journal *Managing Sport and Leisure* and is Co-Founder of The Football Collective, a global network of football scholars. He is also a Co-Editor of the Routledge book series *Critical Research in Football*. On top of this, Dan maintains extensive links within professional sport clubs, is Head of Football Research at Dundee United Football Club and is CEO of the Association of Sporting Directors. Daniel tweets from @parnell_daniel



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First published 2023

by Routledge

4 Park Square, Milton Park, Abingdon, Oxon OX14 4RN

and by Routledge

605 Third Avenue, New York, NY 10158

Routledge is an imprint of the Taylor & Francis Group, an informa business

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British Library Cataloguing-in-Publication Data

A catalogue record for this book is available from the British Library

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data

Names: Roberts, Will (William M.) editor. | Whigham, Stuart, editor. | Culvin, Alex, editor. | Parnell, Daniel, editor.

Title: Critical issues in football : a sociological analysis of the beautiful game / edited by Will Roberts, Stuart Whigham, Alex Culvin and Daniel Parnell.

Description: Abingdon, Oxon ; New York, NY : Routledge, 2023. |

Series: Critical research in football | Includes bibliographical references and index. |

Identifiers: LCCN 2022039467 | ISBN 9781032183091 (hardback) |

ISBN 9781032183114 (paperback) | ISBN 9781003253990 (ebook)

Subjects: LCSH: Soccer—Social aspects.

Classification: LCC GV943.9.S64 C757 2023 | DDC 76.33—dc23/eng/20220917

LC record available at <https://lccn.loc.gov/2022039467>

ISBN: 978-1-032-18309-1 (hbk)

ISBN: 978-1-032-18311-4 (pbk)

ISBN: 978-1-003-25399-0 (ebk)

DOI: 10.4324/9781003253990

Typeset in Goudy

by codeMantra

Contents

<i>Preface</i>	xi
<i>Acknowledgements</i>	xiii
<i>List of contributors</i>	xv

Introduction: Examining Critical Issues in Football Through Sociological Theory	1
--	----------

STUART WHIGHAM, WILL ROBERTS, ALEX CULVIN
AND DANIEL PARNELL

PART I

Established Social Theories and Football **13**

1 Tottenham Hotspur, Fan Identity and Figural Sociology: ‘Yid Army’	15
--	-----------

BONITA LUNN

2 How an Ethos of Amateurism Can Support the Integration of an Ecological Approach to Learning and Development in Football Academies: Too Much Too Early?	26
--	-----------

WILL ROBERTS, MARTYN ROTHWELL, HAYDN MORGAN, JAMES VAUGHAN AND CARL WOODS

3 The McDonaldisation of Football’s Formal Coach Education?: Creating the McCoach	38
--	-----------

ANTHONY BUSH AND SHAUN WILLIAMS

PART II

Emerging Social Theories and Football 51

- 4 Desire, Drive and the Melancholy of English Football: 'It's (not) Coming Home' 53

JACK BLACK

- 5 An Alternative Lens for Grassroots Sport: De-schooling Football 66

ANDY PITCHFORD, BEN MORELAND,
DEBBIE SAYERS AND WILL ROBERTS

- 6 Negotiating Identity Conflict Through Football: Experiences of People Living with Type 1 Diabetes 81

CHRISTOPHER BRIGHT AND GYÖZÖ MOLNÁR

- 7 Professional Knowledge Development in Performance Pathways: A Futsal Case Study Through the Lens of Practice Architectures 93

SIÔN KITSON, PETE VALLANCE AND SIMON PHELAN

PART III

Social Theories of Gender and Sexuality in Football 109

- 8 Experiences of Female Football Referees: Using the Lack of Fit Model to Explore Gender Stereotypes in Football in England 111

LAURA GRUBB, TOM WEBB AND MIKE RAYNER

- 9 Critical Feminism and Football Pundits: Calm Down... It's Just a Woman Talking Football 124

ALI BOWES, MOLLY MATTHEWS AND JESS LONG

- 10 Towards the Application of Feminist-Informed Pedagogical Principles into Coaching Practice: Personal Narratives and Implications for Football Coaches 137

ADI ADAMS, ALICE HUNTER AND ELLIE GENNINGS

- 11 English (Men's) Football, Masculinity and Homophobia:
From Hegemonic to Inclusive Masculinity 149
JAY WILLSON AND RORY MAGRATH

PART IV

Social Theories of 'Race' and Ethnicity in Football 163

- 12 The Racialised Construction of Black Professional
Footballers in Engl(ish) Football: Love the Game, Hate the Player 165
JASON ARDAY

- 13 Black Professional Football Players, Social Capital and Social
Change: A Case Study of Marcus Rashford's Child Poverty
Campaign 174
KEON RICHARDSON

- 14 'Pogba x Stormzy' and the Politics of Race and
Representation: An Introduction to Stuart Hall and British
Cultural Studies 186
MICHAEL HOBSON

- Index* 197



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Preface

This book showcases a range of contributions to the sociological study of football drawing upon contrasting theoretical approaches, facilitating a critical appraisal of the utility of sociological theory when applied to the specific topic of football. Furthermore, the collection offers a unique opportunity to showcase emerging scholars within the academic field. It has been a privilege to work alongside so many talented academics to produce a timely contribution to this field of study, with an eclectic range of theoretical approaches adopted within the book.

Each chapter draws upon a specific sociological theorist to explore a different issue or topic within the domain of football, offering an opportunity to critically reflect upon issues of identity, power, inequality, contestation and controversy within the global game. A range of classical and contemporary sociological theorists are used within each chapter, including theorists commonly used with the sociology of sport such as Elias and Foucault, as well as emergent theoretical approaches within the sociology of sport such as Žižek, Lacan and Illich, amongst others.



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Acknowledgements

We would like to acknowledge the support, guidance and friendship from a number of colleagues in the academic community of whom many have provided the inspiration and motivation for embarking on this project. In this regard, particular thanks need to go to Jason Arday, Alan Bairner, Jack Black, Morph Bowes, Ant Bush, Michael Hobson, Győző Molnar, Haydn Morgan, Andrew Pitchford and Verity Postlethwaite – it's a pleasure to have contributions from a number of these colleagues and friends within this text.

Thank you to all our families, past and present, for the never-ending support and encouragement. Alan and Graham, we miss you!

To all the academic colleagues that have supported us and the students that have inspired us...this is dedicated to you.

Will, Stuart, Alex and Dan



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List of Contributors

Adi Adams is Senior Lecturer in Sport, and former Programme Leader for BSc (Hons) Sport Coaching at Bournemouth University, UK. Adi's teaching, research and professional practice coalesce around the creation of more inclusive, equitable and diverse environments in sport, including a strong commitment to social responsibility and sustaining ethical sport coaching practices. Adi is a UEFA B (Level 3) qualified Association Football Coach with over 15 years' coaching experience, and ten years' experience working in professional football academies.

Jason Arday is Professor of Sociology of Education at the University of Glasgow, School of Education, College of Social Sciences. Previously, Professor Arday was Associate Professor in Sociology at Durham University in the Department of Sociology and the Deputy Executive Dean for People and Culture in the Faculty of Social Science and Health. He is a Visiting Professor at The Ohio State University in the Office of Diversity and Inclusion and an Honorary Professor at Durham University in the Department of Sociology. He holds other Visiting Professorships at Coventry University, London Metropolitan University and Nelson Mandela University. He is a Trustee of the Runnymede Trust, the UK's leading Race Equality Thinktank and the British Sociological Association (BSA). He sits on the Centre for Labour and Social Studies (CLASS) National Advisory Panel and the NHS Race and Health Observatory Academic Reference Group. He is a Fellow of the Royal Society of Arts (RSA).

Jack Black is Senior Lecturer at Sheffield Hallam University, UK and affiliated with the Centre for Culture, Media and Society, where he is Research Lead for the 'Anti-Racism Research Group'. An interdisciplinary Researcher, working within psychoanalysis, media and cultural studies, his current projects include examining the relationship between race/racism and psychosis as well as online hate during international sporting events (*Tackling Online Hate in Football* [AHRC/UKRI]).

Ali Bowes is Senior Lecturer in Sociology of Sport at Nottingham Trent University, UK. Ali is on the editorial boards of *Sociology of Sport Journal* and *Managing Sport and Leisure*, and is on the board of the Football Collective.

Christopher Bright is an Honorary Fellow at the University of Worcester and Welsh Futsal International, UK. His work involves exploring the impact of type 1 diabetes within the field of sport and exercise, with a particular interest in combining sport and peer support as a mechanism, to impact on healthcare outcomes for those with chronic health conditions. This has led to the formation of The Diabetes Football Community, a peer support community established in football, but focused on driving engagement with type 1 diabetes, which Chris founded in 2017.

Anthony Bush is Senior Lecturer (Associate Professor) in the Department for Health at the University of Bath, UK. He is a mixed-methods Researcher, and his research is driven by the power of sport to do good (and cause harm) at an individual level or at societal level. His work seeks to challenge taken-for-granted assumptions and utilises a diverse range of methods in order to provide evidence for alternate solutions to problems. He has produced reports for non-departmental public bodies (NDPBs), national governing bodies of sport (NGBs), private companies and professional sports clubs.

Ellie Gennings is Lecturer in Sports Coaching at Bournemouth University, UK. Ellie's research interests take a broad and holistic approach to sports coaching, where she is interested in social and environmental issues. In 2021, she completed a mixed-methods psychology-based PhD. Her research sought to understand adolescent wellbeing from the perspective of children, and develop and validate a psychometric measure of wellbeing, and enabled her to understand the role of the outdoors within physical activity intervention programmes. She is the Lead Collaborator between Bournemouth University and the Andrew Simpson Foundation where she has recently supported the launch of their most recent initiative #boatgen.

Laura Grubb is a PhD Researcher at the University of Portsmouth, UK. Her main research interest is exploring the professionalisation of women's football. She is also interested in researching the experiences of female football referees and the experiences of football coaches from different cultures.

Michael Hobson is Senior Lecturer in Physical Education, Sport and Youth Development in the Department of Psychology and Pedagogic Sciences at St Mary's University, Twickenham, UK. His research interests focus on the sociology of sport and education; social class in PE and sport; social class and higher education; inequalities in education; racial inequalities in PE and sport and sports interventions for young people at risk of becoming involved in the criminal justice system.

Alice Hunter is Lecturer in Sport Coaching at Bournemouth University, UK. Her research focuses on developing coaching pedagogies, and she completed her Doctorate in Sports Coaching at Cardiff Metropolitan in 2021, which focused on the use of phenomenologically informed explicitation style questioning to

develop understanding of players' decision-making in team sports. She was the U19 Wales Korfball Coach and is a current Player for the Wales Korfball Team and hopes to use her experiences as a Coach and Player to inform both her research and teaching practice as a Lecturer.

Siôn Kitson works as Talent Partnership Manager at the National Governing Body England Hockey, UK. Siôn has previously worked at Sport England and the Football Association in various coaching and sports development roles. Siôn is an ex-Wales International futsal player and has been coaching futsal for 15 years including leading and assisting senior and youth international teams with both England and Wales.

Jess Long completed her undergraduate sport science degree at Nottingham Trent University, UK, with her research project investigating women football pundits.

Bonita Lunn is a Doctoral Research Student at Oxford Brookes University, UK. Her current work examines antisemitism in British football while looking at effective anti-discrimination programmes that combat hatred in sports. In order to minimise antisemitism in society, and notably in British football, she is now developing an educational programme that may be utilised to inform people about the subject.

Rory Magrath is Associate Professor of Sociology at Solent University, Southampton, UK. His research focuses on declining levels of homophobia, with a particular focus on professional sport.

Molly Matthews works in sport and leisure, having completed a Master of Law in Sports Law and an undergraduate degree in Sport Science and Management at Nottingham Trent University, UK.

Győző Molnár is Professor of Sociology of Sport and Exercise at the University of Worcester, UK. Győző's current research focuses on politics, identity and marginalised populations.

Ben Moreland is Lecturer in Sport Development and Coaching and Doctoral Research Student at Plymouth Marjon University, UK. His research interests centre on the experiences of individuals in sport and particularly non-traditional activities. His current work examines the lived experience of mountain bikers, focusing on the embodied and sensory dimensions.

Haydn Morgan is Senior Lecturer (Associate Professor) in Sport Management in the Department for Health at the University of Bath, UK. His research coheres around the connection between participation in sport and physical activity and the enhancement of social inclusion and wellbeing in marginalised populations.

Simon Phelan is Senior Lecturer in Sport, Coaching and Physical Education at Oxford Brookes University, UK. His research revolves around the employment

of ethnographic methodologies to investigate the development of professional coaching knowledge, questioning the role organisational culture plays in shaping learning communities. Beyond this, Simon is an active Coach Developer and Learning and Development Consultant for a number of sports organisations. In this role, he utilises his professional knowledge and current coaching role within England Athletics Youth Talent Programme to support practitioners' continued learning journeys.

Andy Pitchford is Head of the Centre for Education and Teaching Innovation at the University of Westminster, UK. In addition to his work on teaching and pedagogy, Andy has a long association with grass roots sport and The Football Association, which goes back to the early 2000s and his contribution to the team led by Professor Celia Brackenridge, focusing on safeguarding in football. He subsequently led evaluations of academy provision and the FA's Respect programme, and also contributed research to the FA's Youth Review in 2016. He has been active on the boards of community foundations at professional clubs and is currently a Trustee and Coach at his local grass roots club.

Mike Rayner is Associate Head at the University of Portsmouth, UK, with responsibility to provide academic leadership at strategic and operational levels for learning, teaching, assessment and Global Engagement. Mike is a Fellow of The Institute of Leadership and Management (ILM), Fellow of the Chartered Institute for Sports, Management and Physical Activity (CIMSPA), a Senior Fellow of the Higher Education Academy, and an Academic Member of the Chartered Institute of Personnel and Development (CIPD). Mike is also a Reader in the area of Global Sport Management.

Keon Richardson is Sport Development Officer at HR Sports Academy, UK. His research interests in the sociology of sport converge around capital accumulation, sport participation and youth from marginalised backgrounds. He completed his master's degree at the University of Tsukuba, Japan, with his thesis examining the sporting capital development of youth blind football players in Zimbabwe. Keon is also a UEFA B Futsal Licensed Coach and has grown blind football in Southern Africa, introducing the game in Zimbabwe, Zambia, Botswana and South Africa.

Martyn Rothwell is Senior Lecturer and Researcher in the Sport and Human Performance Research Group at Sheffield Hallam University, UK. He conducts field-based research that identifies key constraints on talent development. More recently this has included adopting ethnographic and case study research methods to explore how sociocultural constraints influence athlete development and preparation in applied settings.

Debbie Sayers is a Solicitor with a PhD in Human Rights Law. She is a published author on human rights matters. She founded Salisbury Rovers FC in April 2016. The club takes a player-led, human rights-based approach to football. She

is a Member of the national Children's Coaching Collaborative, as well as a committee member of the National Children's Football Alliance.

Pete Vallance is Lecturer in Sport and Exercise at Coventry University, UK. His practice focuses on coach development through field-based research. Pete is an ex-England International Futsal Player and High-Performance Coach for the England U19 and U21 Futsal Squads. He is also an experienced Coach Educator and Coach Mentor for the FA. His research interests are in high performance cultures and elite behaviours in sport.

James Vaughan is Head of Football and Coaching Psychology and Research Coordinator at AIK in Stockholm, Sweden. His research views football as an emergent feature of the sociocultural ecology and proposes that sociocultural constraints influence playing style and player's creative development. James is an active Coach, Coach Developer and Researcher in football.

Tom Webb is Senior Lecturer in Sport Management at the University of Portsmouth, UK. He has published widely on the subject of sports officials at both elite and grassroots level. Tom works with officials and sporting organisations from around the world.

Shaun Williams is Senior Lecturer in the Department for Health at the University of Bath, UK. His research spans different pedagogical contexts from grassroots to elite and is indicative of his coaching background. Specific research areas would include critical work around the deployment of digital technologies in sport, applied coaching practice and exploring more collaborative ways to better understand and support coach learning.

Jay Willson holds a master's degree in Sport Development and Management from Solent University, Southampton, UK. He has conducted research on masculinities and sexualities in competitive team sport.

Carl Woods is Senior Research Fellow within the Institute for Health and Sport at Victoria University, Australia. His research interests reside at the intersection of ecological psychology, social anthropology and sport science, where he explores concepts of knowing, skill, learning and education. He has an extensive background in both academia and the industry, having held various positions within multiple Australian Universities and the Australian Football League.



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Examining Critical Issues in Football Through Sociological Theory

*Stuart Whigham, Will Roberts, Alex Culvin
and Daniel Parnell*

Introduction

This book showcases a range of contributions to the sociological study of football, facilitating a critical appraisal of the utility of sociological theory when applied to the specific topic of football. Furthermore, the collection offers a unique opportunity to showcase emerging scholars within the academic field. It has been a privilege to work alongside so many talented academics and practitioners to produce a timely contribution to this field of study, with an eclectic range of approaches adopted within the book.

Each chapter offers a sociological exploration of a different issue or topic within the domain of football, offering an opportunity to critically reflect upon issues of identity, power, inequality, contestation and controversy within the global game. A range of classical and contemporary sociological theorists are used within each chapter, including theorists commonly used with the sociology of sport, such as Elias and Foucault, as well as emergent theoretical approaches within the sociology of sport such as Žižek, Lacan and Illich, amongst others.

This book is divided into four main sub-sections. The first sub-section entitled **'Established Social Theories and Football'** includes chapters which draw on Elias and Foucault – two of the most frequently cited theorists within the sociology of sport and football – as well as the widely cited work of Ritzer on 'McDonaldisation'. The second sub-section is entitled **'Emerging Social Theories and Football'** and showcases the application of theorists used comparatively rarely within the sociology of sport and football – namely, Lacan, Žižek, Illich and Maffesoli – as well as the concept of 'practice architectures' which draws upon numerous sociological perspectives. The third sub-section entitled **'Social Theories of Gender and Sexuality in Football'** draws together a theme of proposed chapters, with a specific emphasis on sociological theories relating to gender and sexuality, including contrasting schools of feminist thought and masculinity theories. The final sub-section entitled **'Social Theories of 'Race' and Ethnicity in Football'** also follows the themed approach of the previous sub-section, this time pulling together chapters focusing on issues of 'race', racism and ethnicity in football, informed by critical race theory and the theoretical approach of Hall.